In Turkey, internal coercion and expansionary ambitions are official state policy, currently being carried out by a conservative Islamic administration. Its leaders took office 11 years ago, promising they would not repeat the authoritarian nationalism of Kemalism. In fact, they are especially focused on recreating a sub-imperial project in which they gain regional supremacy over Iran, Egypt and Saudi Arabia. In order to do so, they are preserving the despotic tradition of maintaining a large bureaucracy operating under military tutelage. The end of the dictatorship did not eradicate the vestiges of totalitarianism and the actual power of the Parliament remains very weak.[21]

Neo-Ottomanism has persisted in Turkey as the historic ideology of the ruling sectors across a variety of periods, from the heights of the imperial state to the depths of semi-colonial status. Currently, this tradition is being adapted to serve the project of inserting Turkey into a globalised neoliberal order as a regional power. Based on this strategy, Turkey has joined NATO, tolerates the Pentagon's use of its national territory, and has participated in incursions into Afghanistan, Somalia and Iraq, all the while seeking to act as a partner, and not simply a vassal, of the United States. It was in pursuit of these same goals that Turkey offered support for the Islamists fighting in the Syrian civil war.

The Turkish bourgeoisie has embraced neoliberalism and accepted its geo-political horizons. It has benefited from an 8% annual growth in GDP, lifting the country into the ranks of the intermediate economies with several corporations achieving global status. But the storm clouds which are currently affecting all intermediate economies are now threatening Turkey's ascension.

New Islamic free traders have displaced the old secular protectionists, but all of them have abandoned their focus on development in favour of promoting trade liberalisation. They seek to join the European Union and in this enjoy the media's and the stock exchange's active support. The United States endorses Turkey's membership for the same reasons that it supported the entry of Eastern European states into the EU; however, it has been difficult to achieve a consensus within Old Europe about including an autonomous power characterised by so much repression and so little secularism.[22]

The Islamic government hoped to use the Arab revolts to export its model of rigidly conservative neoliberalism. Yet the commotion that spread throughout the region ended up infecting Turkey itself and the Taksim Plaza in Istanbul was transformed into a mirror image of Tahrir Square in Cairo. A wave of demonstrators occupied this site for weeks, protesting against religiously based political and social restrictions and police brutality.[23] This reaction highlighted dissatisfaction with Turkey's neoliberal surgery in a country burdened by attacks